

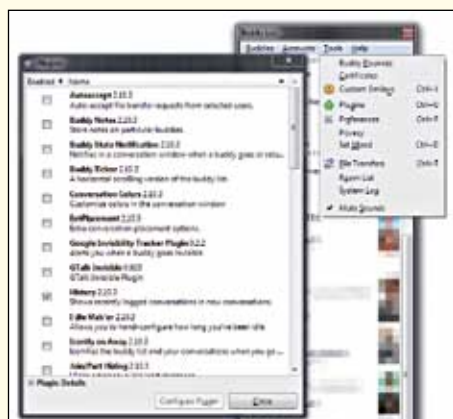
PIDGIN

Instant Messaging clients are not as popular as they used to be in the heyday of the technology. Now most networks will let you chat right in the browser, making it unnecessary to download and install an IM client. Even so, for many purposes they're a lot better than the plain vanilla clients you get in the browser.

For one, applications like Pidgin can handle multiple accounts from multiple services – no switching tabs to see where you got the latest message. You get a consolidated list of contacts, a single application to manage all your instant messaging account, and it even works without the browser open. With Pidgin you can even chat in restricted environments, by configuring it to use a proxy. What's not to like?

■ Pidgin plug-ins

One of the strongest features of Pidgin is that it supports



A list of some of the plug-ins in Pidgin

plug-ins. These can do anything from adding support for a network that Pidgin doesn't support by default to measuring how fast you're typing, or even processing chat messages via a custom command line app.

A number of plug-ins come with Pidgin by default, and many many more are available as third-party add-ons. A number of the plug-ins that ship



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with Pidgin aren't enabled by default, but add useful functionality if enabled.

Installing plug-ins is quite simple, often it's just a matter of downloading the setup program and running it. Some plug-ins however don't set themselves up and you must install them manually. This isn't hard either, your plug-ins are .dll file (or .so files on Linux) located in the plug-in directory in the Pidgin install folder. You'll simply need to extract the

plug-in file in this directory and enable it in Pidgin's plug-ins list.

The Pidgin plug-in list is accessible by clicking on the "Plugins" entry in the "Tools" menu. Here you'll see a list of plug-ins, the plug-in version number and a short description. You can enable/disable plug-ins from here; for some plug-ins, there's an option to configure their settings.

■ Freak friends out by replying before they can send a message

You're probably thinking, if you reply before someone even sends a message, is it even replying? Aren't you just starting the conversation?! Fear not, all will make sense in a little while. You might have noticed



You'll get a notification even when you're not talking to them

that when a friend starts typing a message to you when you're chatting with them, you'll get a notification along the lines of "XYZ is typing...". However, you only get these notifications if your chat window is open, and not otherwise.

What the 'Psychic Mode' plug-in does is enable these notifications even if you're

not actively chatting with someone. The end result? When someone starts typing a IM message to you in order to start a conversation, you'll get a notification even before they've sent you the message!

As long as their message isn't something as short as "hi" you'll probably have enough time to freak them out by sending a message while they're still typing.

■ Get notifications on Windows using Snarl

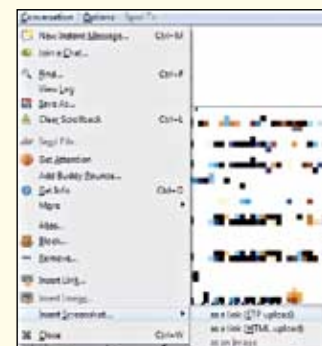
Windows sadly doesn't have an inbuilt notification system, but there are worthy third-party solutions such as Growl and Snarl. These applications run in the background, and any application that supports either Growl or Snarl can use them to display notifications. Quite a few applications do, and many others have plug-ins to add support.

For this, you'll need to download and install Snarl, and download and install 'PidginSnarl', the plug-in for Pidgin that lets it connect to Snarl to show notifications.

You can get Snarl from <http://snarl.fullphat.net/> and the Pidgin plug-in from <http://tthan-ghun.de/Projects/PidginSnarl/>

■ Quickly send screenshots

If you often have to guide people through troubleshooting their computers, pictures can speak more than



Send screenshots quickly